cannot be attributed to just fewer big releases in the first half. Mid-budget films have also struggled to make an impact, with just a few exceptions such as *Kesari-Chapter 2*, *Raid 2* and *Jatt*.

At Cinepolis India, which has 186 of its 430 screens in Tier II and III centres, the situation is improving, but with a caveat. "While overall attendance figures have recovered to near pre-Covid levels—85 per cent of 2019 level in 2024—this is primarily due to the increase in screen count rather than per-screen productivity, which is down 25-30 per cent," says Devang Sampat, the managing director of the multiplex group. "This disparity highlights the underlying challenges the exhibition sector faces. Ultimately, it boils down to the content the industry is churning out." The chain's expansion strategy has seen it open cinemas in Kozhikode, Bhopal, Jaipur, Rajkot and Kannur, with plans to set up shop in Jhansi, Pondicherry and Jodhpur in a few years.

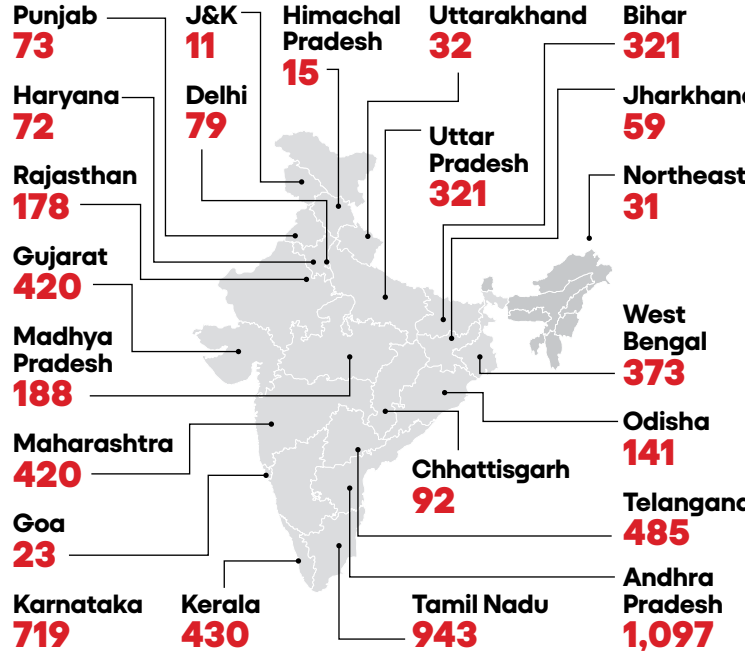
NORTH-SOUTH DIVIDE

Talk to any exhibitor and the conversation ultimately boils down to the lack of a steady stream of compelling films that can lure the audiences back into cinema halls. "Nobody makes movies for the masses anymore," says Yusuf Shaikh, whose family operates five single screeners in Gujarat that are just about breaking even. "We are not ready to understand who our audience is or [have] ignored who they are." An 'ABCD film', one that connects in all geographic centres, is a rarity, he says. Instead, he praises filmmakers in the South for working out "their target audience and sale and recovery model" as well as marketing, which has resulted in a few films becoming hits even in the Hindi belt. "In the South, actors have their own fan clubs. Even the music and trailer launch are events for them," he adds.

There's no overlooking the fact that the South is way above the rest of India when it comes to big screen viewing. As per cinemaprofile.com, of the 6,877 theatres in India, 54 per cent are in the five southern states. Add Maharashtra, and the figure rises to 70 per cent. Screen density in the South too is much higher than the national average. Ashish Pandey, currently head, programming and strategic initiatives, at MovieMax, has been in the film distribution business for over two decades and has some understanding on why the likes of Andhra, Telangana and Tamil Nadu dominate. "In the South, there's a culture of going to the cinemas. It's not like you are going for the sake of entertainment alone. It's also not considered demeaning to go

SCREEN PRESENCE

India has 6,877 theatres currently, 54% are in the South



Source: cinemaprofile.com

9,000
Approx. number of cinema screens in India. China has 90,000, the US 39,000

16%
Footfalls in cinemas in 2024. Occupancy rate was 32% before the pandemic in '19

₹22,400 CRORE
Loss of revenue to piracy in 2023, per EY report



"What this country needs is cinema halls for the masses. Those who can pay up to Rs 100 and watch a movie"

— YUSUF SHAIKH
Founder of Janta Cinemas